The RuneScape Gold Rush:

Venezuela's Unlikely Economic Lifeline

In Venezuela, killing dragons can pay better than a real job. For thousands of people, what started as a video game has become a genuine way to make a living—proof that, in a country gripped by economic collapse, even a 20-year-old medieval fantasy world can offer something increasingly rare: financial stability.

An Oil-Rich Nation, a Painful Paradox

Venezuela sits on the world's largest proven oil reserves, a resource that should make it one of the wealthiest countries on the planet. For decades, oil revenues fueled expansive social programs, subsidies, and a relatively high standard of living across much of the population.

The 2014–2015 Oil Crash

That stability began to unravel in 2014, when global oil prices plunged from over $100 per barrel to below $50, cutting Venezuela's revenue in half. With the economy so heavily dependent on oil, the drop was catastrophic. The government, already struggling with mismanagement and mounting debt, could no longer sustain its spending.

Inflation, Poverty, and Shrinking Paychecks

What followed was a deep and prolonged economic crisis. Inflation spiraled out of control, eventually reaching astonishing levels—at its peak, more than 1,000,000% (yes, one million percent) in 2018. The bolívar, Venezuela's currency, lost almost all of its value. Basic goods like food, medicine, and hygiene products became increasingly scarce and unaffordable, and millions of Venezuelans were pushed into poverty.

A Day's Work: Just a Few Dollars

Today, the average monthly salary in Venezuela is roughly $3–10 USD, depending on the job and region. That works out to about $0.10–$0.30 per day—far below what's needed to cover basic living expenses.

Enter Old School RuneScape

In this environment, many Venezuelans found an unexpected opportunity in Old School RuneScape (OSRS). The game, a popular, long-running MMORPG, has a thriving real-world trading (RWT) market, where in-game gold can be bought and sold for real money through third-party platforms and trusted community channels.

A New Kind of Job

For Venezuelans, OSRS gold farming quickly became attractive for a simple reason: it could pay far more than a traditional job. By killing high-value monsters like black dragons, completing profitable activities in areas like the Revenant Caves, or farming other in-game resources, players can earn gold that converts to real income—often several times (or even dozens of times) more than the local minimum wage.

When Virtual Gold Became Survival Survival

How RuneScape's virtual economy collided with real-world crisis — and turned a game into a lifeline for thousands of Venezuelans.



Ten hours of farming in Old School RuneScape could earn around $5 USD, potentially equal to nearly two weeks of wages in Venezuela. For many, that money went toward basic necessities like groceries — or even to fund their escape from the country altogether.

The 2019 Blackouts

The crisis reached a new level in March 2019, when nationwide blackouts in Venezuela disrupted daily life and hit gold farmers hard. With widespread power and internet outages, many could no longer access the game, reducing the flow of gold and causing noticeable price fluctuations for commonly farmed resources across the OSRS economy.

Backlash in the Game

Many regular players resented the impact gold farming had on prices, arguing it made supplies more expensive and distorted the game's economy. That resentment soon spilled into the Wilderness, where clans began actively hunting Venezuelan gold farmers, turning economic friction into full-blown in-game conflict.

Jagex Cracks Down

In response, Jagex intensified its crackdown on real-world trading (RWT), banning thousands of accounts linked to gold farming. The move was meant to protect the game's economy and keep the game fair, but for Venezuelans, losing an account often meant losing a vital source of income.

> *"A nationwide power outage in South America affected the economy of a medieval fantasy video game."*

A Striking Paradox

It was a striking paradox: in a country sitting on one of the world's largest oil reserves, citizens found better economic opportunity killing imaginary dragons in a 20-year-old game than working conventional jobs in the real world.

A Virtual Lifeline

In the end, RuneScape's virtual currency became far more than pixels on a screen. For many Venezuelans, it was a way to buy groceries, support loved ones, and — when circumstances became unbearable — sometimes even leave Venezuela behind.

Special thanks: To YouTube creator SirPugger and the Old School RuneScape community for organizing a fundraiser that raised $14,567 for the International Rescue Committee, supporting people affected by the crisis in Venezuela.